

Staying in touch

Touch works only at close range, but it plays a big part in animal communication. Animals often use it when they meet and when they are getting together to mate. In mammals and birds, it helps parents to control their young, as well as to maintain the bonds between parents themselves. Touch is even more important for animals that live in permanent groups. They often spend hours in close contact, exchanging signals by touch.

Touching moment

Despite its size, an elephant's trunk is almost as sensitive as a human hand. Here, two African elephants are meeting and greeting. One has laid its trunk on the other's head and is smelling its temporal gland, just in front of its ear. This gland produces a mixture of chemicals, which give the elephant a complex personal scent. After even a short separation, related elephants greet by touching and rubbing with their trunks, to reconfirm their close connections.



Personal space

Perched on nests made of mud, black-browed albatross chicks wait patiently for their parents to return from the ocean with food. Each nest is surrounded by a personal "buffer zone," which stretches as far as an adult albatross can peck. The parents can come and go, but they attack any other albatross that ventures too close to their nest.

